Mauli Rituals — Client Challenge Brief

Future of Commerce · Marketing Challenge: Integrating Tech & Emerging Tech into Retail

Client brief for classroom use

Sources: 42-minute client Q&A with founder Anita Kaushal (video) + Mauli Retailer Deck, Aug 2026 (42 pp)

Prepared 12 September 2026

Contents

Right-click the contents and choose "Update Field" to refresh page numbers.

1. Executive Snapshot....3
2. The Client at a Glance....3
3. Why Now — Market Momentum....4
4. Who the Customer Is....5
5. Product & Ritual Architecture....5
6. Brand Story & Non-Negotiables....6
7. Business Model Reality....7
8. What the Client Explicitly Asked....7
9. Opportunity Spaces....8
10. Assets the Client Will Provide....9
11. Key Numbers Cheat-Sheet....9
12. The Challenge in One Paragraph....10
13. Sources & Reconciliation Notes....10

1. Executive Snapshot

Mauli Rituals is an independent British luxury wellness brand built on Ayurvedic principles, founded in London in 2015 by Anita and Bittu Kaushal. Born from family heritage — Ayurvedic doctors, herbalists and plant-medicine farmers — and from the loss of their daughter in 2012, whose dream was "to help others feel connected and confident in living." Every product is made in England from India's refined botanicals, formulated natural and science-backed, and organised around rituals rather than single categories.

The brand's positioning in one line, in the founders' words: "authentic luxury" — small-batch, natural, heritage-rooted products that major luxury houses and hospitality brands (Bulgari, Lamborghini, Range Rover, Emirates, Four Seasons, Nobu, One&Only) choose to associate with because of that authenticity. The deck states the ambition plainly: "The next chapter of Mauli is about a world-leading wellness brand rooted in Ayurvedic wisdom."

The core challenge for students: Mauli is a deeply human, story-rich, multi-sensory brand that has barely touched AI, AR/VR or emerging commerce tech — and wants to integrate them without flattening the ritual into a SKU, and without losing the personal touch that is its entire value proposition.

2. The Client at a Glance

Dimension	Detail
Founded	2015, London — by Anita & Bittu Kaushal; born from the founders' heritage and a healing journey after the loss of their daughter in 2012
Founders	Anita Kaushal (face of the brand, lead storyteller) & Bittu Kaushal; family heritage of Ayurvedic doctors, herbalists and plant-medicine farmers
Positioning	"The Art of Wellbeing" — ancient wisdom + high-performance results + sensorial rituals; a refined wellness edit, British made with India's botanicals
Product	Ayurvedic personal care & wellness: precise edits for hair, skin, body and sleep, plus artisan tools and home fragrance; ritual-based, "ageless, genderless, timeless"
Price point	AOV £87 (often £100+); entry products from £24–29; candle £62
Proof points	74 award wins and IP on formulations (per Aug 2026 deck); founder cites 75 on the call; hero Grow Strong Hair Oil has 10–11 awards
Channel mix	D2C 61%; remainder across spa, retail, and amenities / hospitality

Dimension	Detail
Key partners	Space NK (first retailer), Bulgari (9 years, worldwide), Nobu, Four Seasons, One&Only Maldives, Stoke Park (Ambani family), Dishoom, The Dover + Martino's, Lamborghini, Range Rover, Emirates (amenity shortlist)
Geography	UK home market; China via Xiaohongshu (RED) with leading influencer Teresa Chung; UAE via distributor; US deliberately deferred (tariffs); no owned retail stores yet
Marketing spend	~72% Meta / 28% Google — "Meta is becoming more and more challenging"
Acquisition mix	46% new customers / 54% existing
Owned audience	Newsletter 77% open rate; Instagram 36k → 105k followers in one year
Customer profile	Core 35+; deck names them "experimental traditionalists" seeking authentic, eco-luxe products with purpose
Tech posture	AI used only for social content / photography; otherwise deliberately untouched

3. Why Now — Market Momentum (from the Aug 2026 retailer deck)

The deck frames Mauli as sitting "at the intersection of Ayurveda, Beauty, Longevity and Modern Wellness" — and deliberately not reliant on a single SKU or platform for growth:

- Global wellness economy: $6.8 trillion in 2024, forecast to reach ~$9.8–10 trillion by 2029 (Global Wellness Summit '25) — now larger than tourism, sports and the green economy.
- Global Ayurveda market: ~$24 billion in 2026 projected to over $85 billion by 2033 — roughly 19.7% CAGR, one of the fastest-growing sectors within preventative wellness.
- Demographic tailwind: by 2050, one in five people globally will be over 60; spending shifts to longevity, vitality and quality of life.
- Category signal: consumers are "no longer simply buying beauty products — they are investing in longevity, resilience and preventative wellbeing"; demand for sleep and nervous-system-health solutions is growing globally.

- Deck's "Why Now" list: preventative wellbeing becoming mainstream · luxury hospitality embracing holistic wellness · Ayurveda gaining global recognition · ritual replacing routine · authenticity valued over marketing.

4. Who the Customer Is (deck psychographics)

The deck names the target customer "experimental traditionalists" — a precise creative brief for any personalization or AI-concierge work:

- Enjoy exploring cultures and art; seekers of authentic luxury.
- Want eco-luxe products with purpose.
- Want results, and can afford to search for quality.
- Seek products that help them thrive in demanding schedules.
- Want to learn and grow — Mauli's Ayurvedic knowledge appeals to them.
- Do not expect "youth in a bottle" — they want efficacy, safety, and formulas that work with their skin and age.

On the call, Anita confirms the core customer is 35+; when younger audiences engage, "they have absolutely loved the product." Teresa Chung, a leading Chinese influencer and RED/Xiaohongshu advocate for the brand, is quoted in the deck: "Love everything Mauli does."

5. Product & Ritual Architecture (deck)

A "precise edit" across hair, skin, sleep and body — "ageless, genderless, timeless." Formulas are built on four science-backed plant-attribute families: botanicals, adaptogens, aromatherapy and nootropics; the deck claims IP on formulations, sustainable packaging, 16 results-driven spa treatments, and natural formulations (Leaping Bunny certification in progress).

Hero SKU / range	Price	Why it matters
Grow Strong Hair Oil	£34–48 range	The brand's first product (2015); pioneered hair-oiling to a Western audience; 10–11 industry awards; men's gateway product
Supreme Skin Serum	premium skincare	Top-performing skincare SKU; founder's personal favourite ("it's unreal")
Sacred Union Dry Oil	bodycare	Biggest seller of 2025; still top 3; anchor of the Sacred Union collection
Sleep Dharma range	£34–48	Himalayan salts, calm balm, bath & shower oil, pillow mist — sleep & nervous-system health is a

Hero SKU / range	Price	Why it matters
		named growth theme
Kansa tools	£26–88	First to introduce Kansa healing metal to the West: Kansa Dome, Comb, Skealer lymph tool — artisan-made "slow beauty" tools
Sundaram & Silence candle	£62	Hand-blended, hand-poured pure essential-oil candle — home-fragrance entry
Botanical Aroma Reset Remedies	£24 / gift set £64	NEW LAUNCH — November 2026: Surrender, Spirited, Serenity roller remedies for emotional balance "from first light to day's end"

B2B / collaboration evidence from the deck: the Dishoom handwash won Gold at the Natural Health & Beauty Awards within its first year; 2026 saw launches for The Dover + Martino's; corporate gifting clients include Lamborghini ("swift turnaround… most delightful scent" — Lamborghini Marketing Manager); and the amenity range (healing salts, pillow mist, VIP gifting, bespoke co-branding) supports the spa/hospitality channel.

6. Brand Story & Non-Negotiables

These are the "non-negotiables" the course challenge must preserve while adding tech:

1. Authentic luxury — best natural ingredients, small-batch, made in England. Chosen by Lamborghini and Range Rover because "you can feel there was something more."

2. Three pillars — Look good. Feel good. Do good. Products must deliver all three; the founder has discontinued ~5 products that weren't best-in-class ("if I don't need them, I'm not going to sell them").

3. The Mauli thread — every boxed product includes a blessed red thread made by an NGO in India (symbol of protection, connection, and well-being). Giving is built into the product.

4. No dilution, ever — spas are refused diluted / cheaper formulas, even though it hurts economics. Only exception ever considered: airline amenity kits (Emirates), because sub-£1 unit pricing is impossible otherwise — and even those were reformulated, not weakened.

5. Give more in value than you take — the dosha / mind-body questionnaire on the site returns genuinely useful self-care content with no sales push. "That's not marketing hype, we really do care."

6. Founder voice — storytelling is the brand moat. But Anita is deliberately stepping back from being the face ("it makes the brand too vulnerable") — the brand needs a way to carry its story without the founder at the forefront.

7. Business Model Reality

The D2C-vs-partnership dilemma (spelled out in the post-call debrief)

- Brand partnerships (Lamborghini, Range Rover, Emirates) are credibility halo, not profit — "nice to have, but not that profitable." No compounding profit effect.
- D2C is 61% of mix and the profit engine, but barely breaks even on first order given discounting and rising Meta costs.
- Retail economics are brutal: Space NK wants 65% margin + 10–15% marketing contribution + free product + paid placement — viable only for large brands.
- Spa / amenity channel is easier margin-wise and "on brand," but scales slowly.

Discount dependency

- Two annual sale events (September birthday sale, Black Friday, both −20%) have skewed revenue and conditioned customers; the brand wants to wean customers off discounting — but slowly.

Channel incoherence risk

The brand does D2C + spa + retail + amenities + partnerships simultaneously, each speaking to different audiences — "for all of those to look coherent can be quite challenging." Anita's self-identified worst-case marketing scenario: "not always being as coherent as we would like… and not feeling authentic. Also not necessarily reaching the right people."

Audience gap

- Core 35+ customer; TikTok (and younger cohorts) deliberately untouched — "if we do it, we need to do it properly" (discounting culture, posting cadence, spreading too thin). Statistic Anita cited: older TikTok users shop Saturday nights.
- Social growth (36k → 105k in a year, outsourced to a brilliant manager in Thailand who uses AI content) is real — but Anita's worry: "is she building the audience, or just the numbers? … what we now need is community."

8. What the Client Explicitly Asked the Class to Solve

Direct brief items from the call (Anita framed these as open questions and "a task"):

1. AI without losing the personal touch. "We've seen how you translate that ritual and our messaging with AI and how we don't lose the personal touch." How does an AI shopping agent represent a multi-sensory ritual without flattening it to a single SKU? (Her own digital agency admitted: "they don't know.")

2. Personalization at scale. The brand has deep mind-body type (dosha) knowledge — three types (Vata / Pitta / Kapha archetypes), an on-site questionnaire, and rich follow-up content. "So much behind it that would help you create something personalized… that may help with AI. Where we would see it, that's for you to tell us."

3. Limited resources — where to execute? "If we have limited resource, then where's the best place for us to execute and how is something I'd love to learn from you."

4. Emerging tech for communication & retail. Course scope named by the instructor: AR/VR, metaverse, AI — communicating brand positioning to prospects who don't know the brand, keeping the non-negotiables intact.

5. New metrics. The instructor's framing, endorsed by Anita: the metrics used today "in the next 10 years might just not work" — an opportunity to derive new metrics the market hasn't seen yet.

6. A concrete B2B automation opportunity (volunteered by the client): build a community of at-home therapists (mobile massage / skin / hair practitioners who constantly ask to buy products and do treatments). Needs: tiered automated purchasing, subscription potential, and vetting / brand protection — "we will do it, it's just a question of when… if you thought that was interesting, I could send you more details."

7. Community over follower-counting. Converting the 105k Instagram audience into a genuine community.

Framing the students' options (per the instructor): choose a B2B path, a B2C (direct) path, or integrate all paths into one workflow. Mindset flip required: not "how's the brand doing on social?" but "how do you automate and amplify the non-negotiables that make this brand flourish in its own habitat, using tech?"

9. Opportunity Spaces

Synthesis for teaching use — each space maps a client tension to a tech / emerging-tech angle.

Opportunity space	Maps to client tension	Example tech / emerging-tech angle
Dosha-personalized AI concierge	AI vs. personal touch; where to execute with limited resources	Mind-body quiz → AI ritual advisor that recommends rituals, not SKUs; carries Anita's voice without Anita
Sensorial AR/VR retail	Ritual can't be flattened; "product in hand needed to feel good"	AR try / experience rituals at home; immersive spa-partner experiences; virtual Bulgari-suite ritual
Therapist community platform	Explicit client ask; automation of non-negotiables (vetting, tiers)	Self-serve tiered B2B portal + subscription + AI vetting / onboarding
Community & new metrics	Numbers vs. community; new-metrics mandate	Community health index, ritual-completion loyalty metric, "feel-good ROI" beyond open rates
Discount-exit	Sale-conditioned revenue,	Predictive replenishment, membership /

Opportunity space	Maps to client tension	Example tech / emerging-tech angle
journey	margin pressure	ritual subscription replacing the promo calendar
Partnership-to-D2C bridge	Halo without profit compounding	QR / connected packaging on Lamborghini, Emirates and Bulgari touchpoints converting experience into D2C community
Retail enablement tech	Deck is a retailer pitch; retail is the undeveloped channel ("don't land and languish")	Virtual try-well for retail buyers, AI-assisted Ayurvedic training for retail staff, dosha diagnostics as in-store theatre

10. Assets the Client Will Provide

- Brand deck — RECEIVED: "Mauli Retailer Deck" (Aug 2026, 42 pages): positioning, market data, psychographics, product architecture with prices, awards, press, B2B amenity and corporate-gifting offers, and the retailer support programme (account support, Ayurvedic training, founder masterclasses incl. "Know Your Dosha to Unlock Your Potential").
- Product samples for the class (hair oil for men, hero serum for women; class to vote the split).
- Competitor list (~8–9 brands) — named on call: Aesop (phenomenal brand, "not natural, but does a good job of looking natural"), Susanne Kaufmann, Ranavat (US, rebuilt with funding, now in Sephora, ~350k Instagram, strong TikTok — "they nail what they do"), plus mass references Summer Fridays and Rhode as price benchmarks.
- Direct email access to the founder for deeper questions; deck lists functional contacts: Sales (Adam), Marketing (Erin), Orders (Zehra), Operations (Desi) @ maulirituals.com.

11. Key Numbers Cheat-Sheet

Metric	Value	Note
AOV	£87 (sometimes £100+)	Break-even just about on first order after discounting
Marketing mix	72% Meta / 28% Google	Meta effectiveness declining
New vs existing	46% / 54%	Retention-led model
Newsletter open rate	77%	Powered by genuine added value, not

Metric	Value	Note
		promotion
Instagram	36k → 105k in 12 months	Outsourced; AI-assisted content
Discount events	2 per year, −20% each	Revenue skewed; exit desired but gradual
Awards	74 (deck) / 75 (call)	Hero hair oil: 10 (deck) / 11 (call)
Retail margin demand	65% + 10–15% marketing (Space NK)	Why D2C / spa carry the model
Channel mix	D2C 61% / spa + retail + amenities 39%	The strategic dilemma
Wellness economy	$6.8T (2024) → ~$9.8–10T (2029)	Global Wellness Summit '25, per brand deck
Ayurveda market	~$24B (2026) → $85B+ (2033)	~19.7% CAGR, per brand deck

12. The Challenge in One Paragraph

> *Mauli Rituals is a 10-year-old independent British Ayurvedic luxury brand that luxury giants seek out, not the other way round. It is profitable-ish, award-laden, and deeply loved by a 35+ audience — and it has almost no technology in its stack beyond boosted posts and AI-assisted Instagram content. Its founder's brief: show us how AI, AR/VR, and emerging commerce can carry a multi-sensory, story-rich ritual to new audiences — without flattening it into a SKU, without discount-led growth, without losing coherence across our five channels, and ideally with new metrics that measure what actually makes this brand work. Do it with limited resources, and tell us where to start.*

13. Sources & Reconciliation Notes

- Sources: (a) 42-minute client Q&A video with founder Anita Kaushal, auto-transcribed 12 Sep 2026 — all quoted language and founder-stated figures come from this; (b) "Mauli Retailer Deck" (Aug 2026, 42 pp) supplied by the client — market data, psychographics, product and pricing details.

- Discrepancy watch-outs (good critical-thinking material for students): award count 74 (deck) vs 75 (call); hair-oil awards 10 (deck) vs 11 (call). Treat all figures as directional, founder/client-stated, not audited.
- The deck is a B2B retailer-facing sales document ("Retailer Deck") — its market-size claims ($6.8T wellness economy, $85B Ayurveda by 2033, 19.7% CAGR) carry no cited source beyond "Global Wellness Summit '25"; students should verify before building on them.
- Auto-transcription artifacts corrected throughout: "Morley" → Mauli, "bulgur" → Bulgari, "ESOP" → Aesop, "Ranavan" → Ranavat, "Dishom" → Dishoom, "Red Book" → Xiaohongshu / RED.